In favour of data surveillance for public safety.

Luca Martinet

In today's world, where every day is more dependent on digital communication and online transactions, the threats of cybercrime, terrorism, and other forms of crime are increasing. One of the essential measures to keep people safe is data surveillance. This type of surveillance includes monitoring social media, financial transactions, and online activities aimed at detecting and preventing threats before they escalate. Although some would argue that this can invade personal privacy, it is crucial for public safety because it provides authorities with the opportunity to combat potential threats (American Civil Liberties Union, 2017).

One of the strongest pieces of evidence for the effectiveness of surveillance in deterrence and solving of security threats is how it has been performing during crises. Consider the 2013 Boston Marathon bombing, for instance, where cameras and mobile phone cameras allowed the police to get images of the suspects swiftly. A task that would be infinitely longer and far less accurate without these tools (Dwyer, 2015). This is an example of the utility of surveillance in real-time threat mitigation, whereby law enforcement can quickly take remedying action. In the modern, vicinal world, surveillance tools have become an indispensable part of life in that they help the authorities in the early identification of potential threats and neutralize them way before they mature, thus guaranteeing public safety.

Statistics further Substantiate this assertion through evidencing how much surveillance aids in the solving and preventing of crime. To that end, the FBI reports an increase of 20% in case resolution in cities where there has been an increased number of surveillance systems (Federal Bureau of Investigation, n.d.). A study by the Urban Institute in 2021 bolsters this evidence: "Cities in which enhanced surveillance has occurred have quicker response times that allow the public to have greater confidence in law enforcement." (Urban Institute, 2021). This further research indicates that data surveillance is not purely some conceptual solution, but an intensive and effective measure capable of yielding real-life dividends. It merely reiterates that small losses of privacy can translate into public safety gains. Data surveillance is efficient and legal as it is supported by the models of public consent, therefore putting into light its endorsement as a means of ensuring security within the public space (Lyon, 2015).

Events of great magnitude such as 9/11, helped to lead to legislation such as the USA PATRIOT Act, which was passed following popular demand for greater security. Despite controversies with the Act, more than 70% of Americans supported the Act shortly after it had passed; this would show that both parties would gladly give up some privacy for security when necessary (USA PATRIOT Act, 2001). In Europe too, response to terrorism has entailed that the governments advocate for increased surveillance. For example, after the attacks that took place in Paris in 2015, the French government passed the Law on Intelligence that enabled the surveillance agencies to monitor digital communication and the use of the

internet (French Government, 2015). Most citizens of this nation felt that such measures would help in curbing the attacks in the immediate future-a sentiment that a consensus had been reached concerning increased security. These examples innately show that data surveillance is regulated and engineered to cater to the needs of security, and society accepts the importance of enhancing public security when required.

In conclusion, data surveillance is crucial for public security, even at some cost to individual privacy. Surveillance has repeatedly proven valuable, whether in deterring crime, aiding investigative efforts, or enabling swift responses to threats, thereby saving lives, and maintaining order. Moreover, the creation of legal frameworks such as the USA PATRIOT Act illustrates society's willingness to embrace surveillance when its purpose is clear and well-justified. While oversight can balance privacy with security, the effective application of surveillance controls can ensure responsible use of collected data without sacrificing the advantages gained from the practice of surveillance. It remains a strong defence against increasingly complex threats, offering the protection needed in our digital world, while also prompting further examination of related issues such as the ethical implications of artificial intelligence in law enforcement (Smith, 2020).

References

American Civil Liberties Union. (2017). *The USA PATRIOT Act: A brief overview*. https://www.aclu.org/other/usa-patriot-act-brief-overview

Dwyer, J. (2015). The Boston Marathon bombing: How it changed the game for security and privacy. *Journal of Digital Security, 12*(3), 45-67.

Federal Bureau of Investigation. (n.d.). *Crime in the United States*. https://www.fbi.gov/services/cjis/ucr

French Government. (2015). *Law on intelligence*. https://www.legifrance.gouv.fr/loda/id/JORFTEXT000031042529

Lyon, D. (2015). *Surveillance society: Monitoring everyday life*. Open University Press.

Nissenbaum, H. (2010). *Privacy in context: Technology, policy, and the integrity of social life*. Stanford University Press.

Smith, J. (2020). Public attitudes toward surveillance and privacy: A study of social media use. *Journal of Social Media Studies, 8*(4), 123-145.

United States Congress. (2001). *USA PATRIOT Act*. Public law 107-56. https://www.congress.gov/bill/107th-congress/house-bill/3162/text